By the late fourth century BCE Arachosia was part of the Mauryan state. Following Alexander's death, Seleucus I Nicator emerged as king of Syria and parts of western Asia but he failed to hold on to south-east Afghanistan and the Indus area, being forced to make peace with Chandragupta Maurya. Through a diplomatic detente the Seleucid king ceded Gandhara, Arachosia, and Paropamisadae (the ancient Greek name for the south-eastern part of present-day Afghanistan). In return he received 500 elephants and a female relative of Seleucus (for a matrimonial alliance). Paul Kosmin, historian of the Seleucid empire, believes that this was a mutually beneficial exchange: 'Geopolitically, Seleucus abandoned territories he could never securely hold in favour of peace and security in the east.'[9] As for Chandragupta, he 'gained unchallenged expansion into India's northwest corridor. His gift of elephants may have alleviated the burden of fodder and the return march!'[10] What Arachosia was called in Mauryan times remains unknown, but a people called Kambojas are mentioned in sources of that era as locally resident. From the geopolitical perspective these territorial acquisitions meant that the Mauryan monarch's powerful pan-Indian empire now had unfettered access across this part of Asia.

Ashoka's communications were one element of this larger lineage of interconnections that left a mark on Afghanistan, a land whose fortunes had for long been tied to those of political overlords located thousands of kilometres distant. The great trade and military routes in this part of Asia passed through its territory, so the populace was no doubt habituated to the comings and goings of kings and conquerors.[11] All the same, like populaces around other edict sites, it may well have cogitated and scratched its head for a long time when first confronting Ashoka's epigraphic scrawls in the vicinity. While here we look at the first of Ashoka's epigraphs in Afghanistan, some years later several more were put down in that remote region, a couple of them in Kandahar itself.[12] Two others were in the valley of Laghman in eastern Afghanistan, carved into *in situ* stones on ridges